

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

Phonology 2

Designing a phonology



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Assignment

1 | What do you want your language to sound like?

Describe it in your own words, or compare it to an existing language. Is it supposed to be harsh, fluid, guttural, liquidy, melodious, brutal? Will it sound like Italian, German, Nahuatl, Wu, Mohawk, Wolof? What sounds do you consider to be "brutal/harsh/guttural/any other adjective you expressed"? Why? Can you identify elements they have in common (place or manner of articulation, voicing, presence in a given language...)?

2 | Record and/or transcribe a sentence in your language

It doesn't need to be an *actual* sentence with a set meaning. Try to arrange sounds you want to have in the language in a way you're pleased with.

Transcribe it as accurately as possible.

If you can't pronounce it fluently enough to record it, that's fine! The transcription will be enough.

3 | Place all the sounds in an IPA table and vowel chart

You can do this in any spreadsheet or text editor you like, or even in an image editing piece of software.

4 | Define some syllable rules

Which clusters are allowed? Can any two vowels be next to each other? What about two similar consonants?

5 | Make up some words

You can do so by hand or with the help of an automated generator. Here are a few:

- [Awkwords \(Web\)](#)
- [Zompist's Gen \(Web\)](#)
- [Lexifer \(Install\)](#)

6 | Deconstruct the syllables of 5 of them

Pick 5 **polysyllabic** (that have more than one syllable) words at random, and note where their syllables begin and end using whichever notation of the ones described above you feel comfortable with. Trees much appreciated.

Do so following the Maximal Onset Principle described in this document.

7 | Check your rules!

Check that your words and their syllables' delimitations conform to your rules.

Once you're done with all of this, put it together with your notes and questions in a document and send it to me, preferably as a PDF.